Schedule

Neil Golson — SXSW 2026 Schedule

Austin, TX | March 12–19

Thursday — March 12

- **6:00–8:00 PM — Realtor.com Recruiting Event**
  Senior talent, operators, future leaders.
- *Neil speaking*
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Friday — March 13 (Realtor.com Open House @ Austin Office)

- **9:30-10:30 - Bureau Updates with Mickey**
- **10:30-11 - Bureau LT**

- **11:30 AM–12:30 PM — Realtor.com Open House: Food + Music**
  Hannah Dasher (TikTok food creator)
  - Live food tasting (1 hr)
  - Live performance (30 min)
  - Michael from HarperCollins attending

- **1:00 - update meeting with Michael Aulisio, VP & Publisher at HarperCollins to update on exciting new project**
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- **2:30–3:30 PM — NAR PropTech Pitch Battle**
  Nine startups. NAR + REACH Canada partnership.

- *****Arrive by 3pm to The LINE Austin, Topaz Ballroom 1-3**
- **4:00-5:00 PM — Is Brand Dead? The Brand Leader's Playbook for the AI Era**
  Panelists: Neil Golson, Dawn Holliday (Dir, Consumer Insights for Taco Bell), Isobell Roberts (Chief AI Officer for Brandcomms.AI), Adam Cook (Creative Lead, Hershey)
  Location: The Line Hotel / Topaz Ballroom 1-3
  Presented by: Brandcomms.AI **Link to NG's Discussion Guide**

- **4:00–5:00 PM — House Warming Party @ Realtor.com HQ**
  Kickoff gathering for partners, press, and industry leaders.
  Featuring live music + Tecovas boot giveaway.

- **Dinner w/Matt Wurst crew at III Forks, 7:30pm**

Saturday — March 14

- **10:00–11:00 AM — Realtor.com × GSD&M Private Marketing Event**
  Invite-only showcasing the Nearly Home campaign.

- **12:00–1:00 PM — "Live from" Realtor.com Open House**
  Wall Street Journal & Barron's podcast recordings.

- **2:00–3:00 PM — Women × Wealth: Closing the Gap**
  Women's role in homeownership and wealth creation.

- **4:00–5:00 PM — Generational Wealth & the American Dream**
  Supply, access, and preserving the pathway forward.

- **7pm - Samsung Ads – Invite-Only Dinner @ Uchiko**
  4200 N. Lamar, Austin, Texas

- **10pm - Networking Event w/Matt Wurst @ 10pm at Corner bar at JW Marriott**

Sunday — March 15

- **10:00 AM-11:00 AM — Retail at the intersection of Music and Merchandise**
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- **11:00 AM–12:00 PM — Tech Transforming Real Estate**
  Tools, platforms, and the modern home journey.

- **1:00–2:00 PM — Access to Homeownership Starts with Building More Homes**

- **3:00 - 4:00 — Hit Pause w/Yahoo & Axios Communications**
  Historic Scoot Inn | 1308 E. 4th St, Austin, TX 78703

- **iHeartRadio Dinner**

Monday — March 16

- Noah Kahan Premiere @ 2:30 - Paramount Theater
- GSD&M Party 6:30-11:00pm

Tuesday — March 17

- 2:00 - 3:30pm – GSD&M Intros & In-person Panel Dry Run

Wednesday — March 18 (Closing Day)

- **10:00–11:00 AM** — **On-Stage Panel Appearance**
  Panelists: Neil Golson, Jennifer Bridie (VP Marketing, Southwest Airlines), Helen Melluish (VP Marketing, VRBO/Expedia), Kate Sheehy (Co-Chief Strategist, GSD&M)
  Location: The Line Hotel / Topaz Ballroom 1-3
  Presented by: GSD&M

- **1:00pm – 2:00pm CT** **How AI Systems Will Make Brands More Human**
  Austin Marriott Downtown - Waterloo Ballroom 3
  Panelists: Suzana Apelbaum, Head of Creative and Innovation, Google Media Lab, and Paul Aaron, CEO of Addition

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Thursday — March 19

- **All Day** — **Luck Reunion – Willie Nelson's Ranch (Luck, TX)**

3/12 RDC Recruiting

Good evening. I'm Neil Golson, VP of Brand & Creative here at Realtor.com

A question I look forward to hearing a lot this week from people visiting Austin is a pretty simple one: **"Is it finally time to buy that house in Austin?"**

For a few years the answer was probably not.

Austin was the **poster child** for the housing frenzy — homes selling in days, bidding wars everywhere, buyers waiving inspections just to compete.

You didn't really shop for a home. You **survived combat** to buy one.

But markets move.

Right now Austin has quietly shifted into one of the **strongest buyer's markets in the country**. **Inventory is up**. Homes are for sale longer. And in many parts of the city there are actually more sellers than buyers.

Which means something that would've been almost **impossible a few years ago** is happening again.

Buyers have time to think. They can **compare homes**. They can **negotiate**.

They **have an edge**.

And helping people find that edge is exactly **what we're building at Realtor.com**.

Our mission is to **help more Americans find their way home**.

It sounds simple. It is not simple. But housing is one of the most complicated markets in the world. It's **emotional**. It's **financial**. It's deeply **local**. And it **changes constantly,** as anyone who bought in Austin in 2021 can tell you.

Millions of people are trying to make sense of it — while making one of the **biggest financial** decisions of their lives. Often while also managing a job, kids, and a mild existential crisis about whether they're making the right call.

So the real challenge **isn't** building another search site.

It's building a platform where the **best data,** the **best technology**, and **real human expertise** come together — so that when someone is **standing in a kitchen** deciding if this is the one, they feel confident enough to say yes. Or confident enough to walk away..

We call this the **Home of the Expert Edge**.

Because when the stakes are high, people don’t want more information.

They want reassurance that they’re making the right move.

What I love about this problem — and why I think it attracts a **certain kind of builder** — is that it refuses to stay in one lane.

It's a **data problem**. It's a **design problem**. It's a **behavioral psychology problem**. It's a **technology** problem. And yes, occasionally it's a "how do we make someone **feel something**" problem, which is where my team comes in.

Whether you work in **technology, design, data, or creative** — the output isn't just clicks or engagement metrics.

It's the **place someone wakes up in the morning**.

The place **someone's kids grow up**.

The place someone **builds their life**.

That's a **meaningful problem** to work on.

You’ll hear next from our **CTO** about the technology shaping where the **platform goes next**.

And from our **Chief People Officer** about the culture and the **kind of builders** we’re bringing into this team.

But if the idea of **helping millions of people** make one of the **biggest decisions of their lives** — with better data, better tools, and better guidance — sounds interesting to you…

then you’re in the right room tonight.

Welcome to Realtor.com, welcome to Austin, and welcome to SXSW.

3/13 - BrandComms Panel - NG Talk Track

Friday, 13 March 2026 4:00pm – 5:00p
Session Title: Is Brand Dead? The Brand Leader's Playbook for the AI Era.

Format: Panel • Track: Brand & Marketing • Audience Level: Intermediate Session

Participants
Moderator: Isobell Roberts, Chief AI Officer and Co-Founder
Panelists:

- Neil Golson, VP, Brand and Creative at Realtor.com
- Dawn Holliday, Director, Consumer Insights at Taco Bell
- Adam Cook, Creative Director at Hershey

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- For – event lead up support & speaker liaison.

Section 1: The State of Brand in the AI Era
Has the role of brand fundamentally changed in the AI era — or is AI exposing which brands had strong fundamentals all along?

- Targeted Question for Neil: Neil, you've said AI has made content infinite – how has this affected your sense of how core fundamentals like coherence and brand strategy are realized when it comes to creative?

  AI made content free and infinite. **But it also made trust scarce.**
  Paradox: when anyone can generate anything**, coherence** becomes **the trust signal.**
  Proof actual humans made deliberate choices and are standing behind them**.**

  In **real estate, trust isn't optional**—it's oxygen. We're asking people to make the largest financial decision of their lives. If your brand shows up fragmented—different voice on Instagram than in your app, different promise on TV than on your website—**you're not being agile. You're eroding trust**.

  We quantified this with our 'Nearly Home' platform with Reba McEntire.
  One human **problem**. One recognizable **authority figure**. One **product resolution**. One **signature close**. That coherence drove a +17% response lift over prior work.

  So brand isn't less important in an **AI-saturated environment**.

  It's the **only trust architecture** we have
  when **everything** else **can be synthesized**."

- Targeted Question for Dawn: Where does the advantage lie for marketers when the same tools are accessible to everyone? How do we protect against sameness?
- Targeted Question for Adam: Adam, you've called AI the most empowering creative shift of your career. Where are you seeing the biggest real unlock in creative development? What is the new 'remit' for brand owners and traditional creatives in this new world?

Section 2: The New Creative Brief
How does the creative brief and process need to evolve when AI can generate at scale — and what first principles need to remain paramount?

- Targeted Question for Neil: You know first-hand the importance of maintaining and continuing to build trust – what's your perspective on how brands curate and leverage new tech while future-proofing brand success? What absolutely must be locked in before you let AI scale anything?

  The **brief is evolving** from 'what do we say?' to
  'what must **remain locked** in across all outputs so people still trust it's actually us?'

  Tension: AI is **extraordinary at permutations**.
  But every variation **slightly degrades your brand's signature**. Your voice becomes **probabilistic**. Your **point of view gets averaged out**.

  We now design what I call a **trust framework**—the non-negotiables that signal 'this is definitely from Realtor.com, not a bot pretending to be us.' That includes:
  - The **audience tension** we're **solving**
  - The **emotional outcome** we're **creating**
  - **Tonal boundaries**
  - Proof architecture**—real experts, real data, real humans** who answer

  Real example: We recently redesigned our Wall Street Journal & New York Post print. We wanted to move from **systemic product-led design** to **art-forward storytelling**, specifically a claymation style that would stand out in a crowded landscape.

  AI lets us explore that vision. We could **iterate** on complex textures and characters in **real-time**. What would have taken **weeks of manual fabrication** happened in **days**.

  But here's where the **trust framework** matters:

  We had to lock in our brand's visual language before we let AI generate anything. Claymation spans a **massive aesthetic range**—we audited our design system first and landed on a minimalist claymation with a a palette that **fit our established identity**. Then creative team worked upscaling, retouching, fine-tuning against **brand guidelines**.

  If we'd just generated and shipped? It wouldn't have been on-brand. It wouldn't have been print-quality. And it definitely **wouldn't have built trust**.

  The internet's training data is built on **averages and patterns**. Your **taste is the trust** signal. If everyone has the same tools, advantage shifts to whoever protects their **distinctive point of view** with more discipline.

Section 3: The Real Productivity Unlock

Where is AI genuinely expanding marketing capability and unlocking growth — not just stripping out cost?

- Targeted Question for Neil: Neil, you oversee a multi-faceted business – how has AI unlocked growth in business units which didn't have the luxury of big budgets or resources? Can you tell us about evolution of AI creative for Realtor.com, and how shift from internal production to agency/expert-led production supported new opportunities?

  The real unlock isn't cost savings—it's **capability expansion**. AI lets you fund growth in parts of your business that were previously starved.

  Real example: We worked with Brandcomms.ai on **creative for our seller audience**. That's a **high-growth**, emerging business for us,
  but it traditionally **wouldn't get premium creative** production budget.

  We would've **had to make an impossible choice**: invest in seller creative or invest in our core buyer business.

  AI eliminated that trade-off.

  We created a visual style that broke through and **visualized our core value prop** in a compelling way. It's now one of our **top-performing ads** of 2025.

  We got **production value and creative breakthrough** for a business that would've otherwise gotten templated work or nothing.

  But—and this is critical—we **didn't just generate and ship**.

  Mark Twain line: 'I didn't have time to write a short letter, so I wrote a long one instead.' AI is **phenomenal at writing the long letter—fast**. But the short letter—the disciplined, clarified, **trustworthy** version—still requires human judgment.

  We curated everything. We made sure messaging was accurate. We kept our brand voice intact. We added **real proof points**.

  The **speed came from AI**. The **trust and judgment** came from us.

  Without that compass pointing toward True North, you're just **racing to a red light**.

Section 4: Empowering Teams to Fight The War Against 'Bad Creative, Faster'
If AI tools are rapidly becoming table stakes, where does real competitive advantage come from — and how do brands avoid scaling 'bad creative' fast?

- Targeted Question for Adam: You've warned that protecting old approaches can fail stakeholders. What mindset shift do leaders need to make right now?
- Targeted Question for Neil: You've said brand isn't dead — trust is just being stress-tested faster. What should every CMO in this room start doing differently on Monday morning?

  Start by asking: Are we **building trust** or just **extracting it**?

  Brand isn't dead. Trust is just being stress-tested faster than ever.

  Here's what I'd do Monday morning:

  1. **Measure beyond performance. Measure trust.**
     If AI work performs well but your brand trust scores drop,
     you're **borrowing from your future**.

  2. **Define your trust framework before you scale anything.**
     What must remain locked in so people know it's actually you? That's not a creative brief—that's your competitive moat.

  3. **Ask the uncomfortable question every time: Should we tell ppl we used AI?**
     I don't have a universal answer. But consumers are getting smart about this. They can feel when something's synthetic. And if they find out later you used AI and weren't transparent? The trust damage is massive and it compounds.

  4. **Protect what makes you distinctive**.
     Your voice. Your point of view. Your values. If you let AI outputs go straight to market without human oversight, your brand will start sounding like everyone else. And in a world where **synthetic content is everywhere**, 'sounds like everyone else' reads as 'probably fake.'

  The leaders who win will use AI to **get more capable while protecting**—maybe even strengthening—their credibility.

  They'll decide with clarity and courage **which messages deserve to exist**, and which ones are just algorithmic noise.

- Targeted Question for Dawn: Dawn, you've been very clear that AI should amplify what makes a brand distinctive — not dull it. Where do you see teams most at risk of losing their edge as they scale AI-driven creative?

Fire Starter Questions to build the flow and conversation to extract your unique perspectives, contrasts and expertise

Has it become more, or less important for brands to deliver a coherent brand and campaign universe that actually delivers results. Why?

More important. Radically more important.Here's the paradox we're living in: AI just made content infinite and free. But it also made trust scarce.When anyone can generate anything, how do you know what's real? How do you know what's been manipulated? How do you know who's actually behind the message?Coherence is now a trust signal. It's proof that a human organization made deliberate choices and is standing behind them consistently.And in real estate? Trust isn't optional. It's oxygen. We're asking people to make the largest financial decision of their lives. If your brand shows up fragmented across touchpoints—different voice on Instagram than in your app, different promise in your TV spot than on your website—you're not being agile. You're eroding trust.We saw this quantified with our "Nearly Home" platform with Reba McEntire. One human problem. One recognizable authority figure. One product resolution. One signature close. That coherence—that proof that real humans made real choices—drove a +17% response lift over prior work.So brand isn't less important in an AI-saturated environment. It's the only trust architecture we have when everything else can be synthesized.

How has / do you see the creative process shifting? Is the creative 'brief' shifting? How so.

The brief is evolving from "what do we say?" to "what must remain invariant across all generative outputs so people still trust it's actually us?"

Because here's the tension: AI is extraordinary at permutations. But every variation it creates slightly degrades your brand's signature. Your voice becomes probabilistic. Your point of view gets averaged out.

The creative process now requires two distinct muscles:

- Systems thinking: Define the narrative spine, the constraints, the emotional thesis—the things that signal "this is definitely from Realtor.com, not a bot pretending to be us."
- Generative velocity: Use AI to explore, prototype, stress test, and scale at speed.

The brief used to be a document. Now it's more like a trust framework. It defines the non-negotiables: audience tension, brand role, proof architecture, emotional outcome, tonal boundaries.

Everything else becomes iterative at machine speed.

We use AI for asset resizing, headline variants, script drafts, rapid A/B generation. But the core insight—the thing that signals human judgment was applied—still requires actual humans. The internet's training data is built on averages and patterns. Your taste is the trust signal.

If everyone has access to the same generative tools, advantage shifts to whoever protects their distinctive point of view with more discipline.

How have you handled shifting consumer sentiment, competitive noise, and volatile market conditions.

By treating trust as the metric that matters most when everything else is unstable. Housing's been chaotic. Interest rates up. Inventory constrained. Competitors like Zillow and Homes.com flooding share of voice with aggressive spend. And now AI-generated content is making it harder for consumers to know what's real, what's editorial, what's advertorial, what's completely synthetic.

Our strategic choice: don't out-shout. Out-clarify. Build trust signals into everything.

We leaned into "Expert Edge" positioning. In uncertainty, authority wins. But authority isn't about being loud—it's about being trustworthy. Real experts. Real data. Real humans who will answer when you call.

We also made a deliberate choice about transparency. When we use AI in our creative process, we're thoughtful about where the human judgment lives. Because if consumers can't tell whether they're talking to a person or a bot, whether an image is real or generated, whether advice comes from expertise or a pattern-matching algorithm—trust collapses.

Internally, we built decision filters: What moves response rate? What lifts consideration? But also: What maintains trust? What signals competence without triggering skepticism? When you anchor to trust as the leading indicator, the other metrics follow.

How you've navigated channel complexity, and limits on budget and time, while managing fluctuating demand and organizational expectations?

By designing for one story that works everywhere, but always feels like it came from actual humans.

TV isn't YouTube. CTV punishes slow openings. Social rewards disruption. Print demands instant clarity. But the core narrative—and the trust signals—have to survive all of them.

We built a simple rule: Brand, problem, and authority in the first 3 seconds. But here's the trust piece: that authority has to be immediately credible. Real person. Real expertise. Real stake in your outcome.

Because AI made it stupidly easy to fake authority now. Generated expert photos. Synthetic testimonials. Algorithmic advice that sounds confident but has zero accountability behind it.

Budget limits actually help here. When you can't spend everywhere, you can't afford to waste trust on sloppy executions. You test what builds credibility and double down. You kill the stuff that looks good on a dashboard but makes people skeptical.

The internal conversation is shifting too. Creative wants excellence. Finance wants ROI. But now the C-suite is asking: Are we building trust or just extracting it? Are we investing in credibility or mining it for short-term wins?

When you can show that trust-building creative amplified a $40M media buy by 17%—and protected the brand at the same time—everyone gets aligned fast.

What advice would you offer to other leaders curious in applying AI tools for creative?

Start with this question: Where does AI make us better, and where does it make us less trustworthy?

The productivity unlock of AI isn't just cost savings. It's capability expansion.

There are two types of work where AI changes the game:

- First, the low-leverage labor that eats your team's time. Resizing assets. Versioning copy. Alt headlines. Competitive scans. Script variations. This stuff has to get done, but it doesn't require human creativity. Use AI here. Free your team up for actual thinking.
- Second—and this is where it gets interesting—work you previously couldn't afford to do at all.

    Real example: We worked with Brandcomms.ai on creative for our seller audience. That's a high-growth, emerging business for us, but it traditionally wouldn't get premium creative production budget. We would've had to make a Sophie's choice: invest in seller creative or invest in our core buyer business. AI eliminated that trade-off.

    Brandcomms.ai let us create a visual style that broke through and visualized our core value prop in a compelling way. It's now one of our top-performing ads of 2025. We got production value and creative breakthrough for a business that would've otherwise gotten templated work or nothing.

That's not just efficiency. That's unlocking growth in parts of your business that were previously starved.

But—and this is critical—we didn't just generate and ship. We curated everything. We made sure messaging was accurate. We kept our brand voice intact. We added real proof points. The speed came from AI. The trust and judgment came from us.

Here's the thing your team needs to understand: AI predicts the next word based on patterns in its training data. It doesn't understand truth. It doesn't understand consequences. You're still responsible for whether what you're saying is accurate, legal, and actually real.

And protect what makes your brand distinctive. Your voice. Your point of view. Your values.

If you let AI outputs go straight to market without human oversight, your brand will start sounding like everyone else. And in a world where synthetic content is everywhere, "sounds like everyone else" reads as "probably fake."

Here's the uncomfortable question: Should we tell people when we've used AI?

I don't have a universal answer. But I think we need to ask it every time. Because consumers are getting smart about this. They can feel when something's synthetic. And if they find out later you used AI and weren't transparent? The trust damage is massive and it compounds.

Finally, measure beyond performance. Measure trust.

If AI work performs well but your brand trust scores drop, you're borrowing from your future. If it performs well and trust holds or grows? That's the unlock.

Brand isn't dead. Trust is just being stress-tested faster than ever. The leaders who win will use AI to get more capable while protecting—maybe even strengthening—their

credibility. They'll decide with clarity and courage which messages deserve to exist, and which ones are just algorithmic noise.

3/14 - Nearly Home Panel

Nearly Home Panel - SXSW 2026

Beyond the Endorsement: Aligning Celebrity, Creativity, and Brand

Friday, March 14, 2026 | 45 minutes

Strategic Overview

KEY INTELLECTUAL TERRITORY:
- Celebrity as trust shortcut (not just awareness)
- Platform thinking vs. campaign thinking
- Coherence as trust signal
- How brands help people navigate life-defining financial decisions

CROSS-PANEL SYNTHESIS:
Your AI/Brand panel (earlier today) + this celebrity panel = same conversation. Both about building trust at scale when everything can be synthesized.

Section 1: Why Invest in a Celebrity?

Q: What were you hoping talent would unlock for the brand?

Housing - largest financial decision of their lives. That requires trust.

Celebrity done right is a trust shortcut.

When someone you already know and trust shows up consistently for a brand,
it signals: this company has been vetted.

What we hoped Reba would unlock was credibility at scale.

She's trusted. She's got decades of real estate investment herself.

She's authentic, grounded, relatable.

Her audience overlaps with our core: homeowners navigating life transitions.

We weren't just looking for a spokesperson.

We were looking for someone whose presence would signal: Realtor.com is the trustworthy choice when it matters most.

Section 2: Why Reba Makes Sense

[Play Jingle :06 spot]

Q: Explain the alignment between the brand and Reba

Reba is not a tech influencer. She's not a real estate agent. Well, she played one

Most people don't think about real estate as a tech problem. Its as a life problem.
Theyre navigating huge transition. They want someone with lived experience who gets it.

Reba owns real estate. She's made these decisions. She's navigated these transitions.
And—this matters—she's spent 50 years building trust through consistency.
People know her. They trust her judgment.
They believe she wouldn't put her name on something that wasn't real.

Her audience is our audience. Country music fans in middle America over-index on homeownership and family-first values in geographic markets where we're strong.

And here's the creative unlock: Reba can sing AND act. That's rare.
You don't always get either from a celebrity.

She can deliver a memorable jingle that's a brand asset.

And she could carry a sitcom format that req'd real performance, not just reading lines.

The alignment isn't 'celebrity endorses product.'

It's 'trusted authority who's lived this experience—and played a REALTOR on TV—helps people navigate the biggest financial decision of their lives.'

That's authentic. That's defensible. That's why it works.

Q: Did her audience change how you thought about media placement?

Y. Reba's audience let us lean into channels we might have under-invested in.

We went broad on linear TV. We added radio—which wasn't in our media mix before. Her audience still engages with traditional media in ways other demographics don't.

We were also able to negotiate unique integration opportunities.

Reba was hosting the Academy of Country Music Awards, which Amazon was distributing.

We premiered our first spot during the show, and sponsored the New Country Artist of the Year award.

Reba introduced that segment and endorsed Realtor.com as her favorite place to find a home—on live TV, in front of her core audience.

That's not just media placement. That's creating moments where the celebrity's authority reinforces the brand message in ways traditional advertising can't buy.

Her presence didn't just de-risk creative ambition. It opened doors to integrations and partnerships we wouldn't have had access to otherwise.

Section 3: Why the Sitcom Strategy?

[Maria leads on creative thinking]

Q: What made you comfortable taking that storytelling risk?

The sitcom format was a calculated risk.

In a world where everyone scrolls past ads, create something people want to watch.

Sitcoms have a century of proof that character-driven storytelling works. People pay attention. They remember. They care what happens next.

What made me comfortable was the coherence. We weren't doing sitcom as a gimmick.

Reba plays someone helping neighbors navigate buying a home. That's a metaphor for what Realtor.com actually does. And since she literally played a REALTOR on her show, it felt authentic.

And the results validated it: +17% response lift over prior creative. The format didn't just entertain people—it made them more likely to use Realtor.com.

[Play :15 Zoomies, :15 Statement Wall]

There's also something deeper at work: great sitcoms are often defined by their houses. The Tanner house in Full House. The apartment in Friends. The Huxtable brownstone. The Banks mansion in Fresh Prince.

These homes become characters themselves—familiar, comforting, aspirational. People recognize them instantly. They build emotional attachment to them.

So when we put Reba in a sitcom about real estate, we weren't just leveraging a format.

We were tapping into decades of cultural memory where sitcom houses represent belonging, family, and home.

That familiarity and nostalgia created immediate trust. Audiences didn't have to learn a new visual language. They already knew how to feel about what they were seeing.

Section 4: Platform Evolution

Q: Strategically, when do you know a platform has real staying power?

You know when three things happen:

First: The numbers hold or grow over time.

We created three spots in Season 1. While one outperformed the others, all three delivered performance improvement in the same range versus prior creative. That consistency matters.

Most campaigns spike and decay. When your creative rotation holds—and then you can extend it into Season 2—that's a signal the audience isn't getting tired. They're getting more familiar,

which in a trust business is exactly what you want.

Second: The brand becomes inseparable from the platform.

Following the campaign, we saw consecutive months of brand health improvement, awareness growth, and increases in our visit share in the category. Not all of that is because of Nearly Home—but it's part of a coherent system that's compounding.

When people start referring to your brand by referencing the campaign, you've created a mental structure that sticks.

Third: The platform is extensible without breaking.

Nearly Home works as :15s, :30s, :60s. It works on TV, YouTube, radio, social. It works with different products, different audiences, different problems. The core structure—Reba helping someone Nearly Home—can stretch to cover what Realtor.com does.

When all three hold, you don't kill it. You protect it. You evolve it carefully. You treat it like infrastructure.

[Tee up Season 2 and show upcoming graphic]

Section 5: Closing Question

Q: What is the most important ingredient in modern brand storytelling?

The most important ingredient is clarity about the human problem you're solving.

Celebrity, format, media strategy—none of it matters if you don't know the tension you're resolving in someone's life.

Nearly Home works because it starts with a real insight: buying a home is overwhelming, and people need help they can trust.

Once you're clear on that, everything else is in service of solving it.

Our positioning is "The Home of the Expert Edge"—where professional expertise becomes your advantage. That's not a tagline. It's a promise.

Reba is the trust signal. The sitcom format makes the problem relatable. The product—our authoritative data, trustworthy tools, credible experts—shows the resolution.

But if you start with "we need a celebrity campaign" or "we should do something viral," you're

building on sand.

Start with the human problem. Understand what expertise actually solves it. Build the trust architecture around that. Then scale it with the best tools available.

That's how platforms get built. That's how you move from campaigns to infrastructure.

Optional: Provocative Closing Thought

If you want to leave the audience with something memorable:

'Most brands think about celebrity as a performance enhancer—someone who makes your message louder.

We think about it differently.

Reba isn't amplifying our message. She's embodying our values. She's proof that what we say about professionalism, trust, and helping people navigate life's biggest decisions aren't marketing slogans—they're operational principles.

The question isn't "Will celebrity partnerships still work in the future?"

The question is: Will you use them to extract attention, or will you use them to build trust?

Because in a world where AI can generate infinite content and synthetic influencers are everywhere, the only thing that will cut through is actual human credibility.

That's what Reba gives us. That's what REALTORS give consumers every day. And that's what platforms get built on.'

3/18 - GSDM Panel - NG Talk Track

Wed 3/18 10:00–11:00 AM — Official SXSW On-Stage Appearance

Trust, Tech & Disruption: Brand Love When Stakes are High
In a world where travel is unpredictable, housing is uncertain, and consumers are pulling back, how do brands that serve high-consideration decisions earn trust and love? This panel features leaders from Vrbo, Southwest Airlines, and Realtor.com — three brands navigating economic volatility, shifting expectations, and technological change while staying emotionally resonant. We'll explore how tech platforms build human connection, why emotional loyalty matters more than ever, and how creative strategies can evolve to meet the moment.

Link to panel overview

Themes I want to explore:

- How your brand can harness **emotional loyalty** as a competitive edge in times of uncertainty.
- Why your **tech still needs to connect to a human** core and truth.
- Where your product and technology can **evolve creatively** to stay relevant.

Legend
YELLOW: Need info from you
BLUE: Need to create slide content for this
PURPLE: Open conversation

Opening Frame

When I ask you who or what you trust, what comes to mind?

Most people don't name a brand first. They think about a person. A moment when something mattered. A time when things didn't go perfectly and someone showed up anyway.

And yet, when it comes to brands, trust has become one of the most overused, and perhaps misunderstood, words we have. That's exactly why we assembled this group of brand leaders today:

- Helen Melluish, VP Marketing at Expedia Group, leading Vrbo. 2-3 sentence bio.
- Jennifer Bridie, VP Marketing at Southwest Airlines. 2-3 sentence bio.
- Neil Golson, VP Brand & Creative at Realtor.com 2-3 sentence bio.
- And I'm Kate Rush Sheehy, CSO at GSD&M, a full-service agency that was started in Austin 55 years ago and has the great pleasure of partnering with great brands like these to put a fine point on how we deepen the connection and desire people have for them.

What excites me for today is that these brands don't operate in low-stakes categories. They that influence life-level decisions, like…

- Where families live and build equity
- Where they create lasting memories
- Whether they feel financially secure enough to make major moves

Travel, housing, and vacations are some of the highest-stakes decisions people make… not just financially, but emotionally. When things break, plans change, or expectations aren't met, that's when brands are truly tested.

What's also interesting is that all three of these brands are *tech platforms* but none of you win on tech alone. You win on reassurance, clarity, and confidence in moments that matter. So today is largely about what actually builds brand love when consumers are anxious, skeptical, and paying attention.

We'll cover:

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Act I: The Emotional Stakes

Alright, first question for the group: What is the real emotional fear your customer brings to you before they even think about your brand? In other words, why is trust critical and when is it most important in your category today?

In housing, earning trust isn't about helping people dream—it's about helping them feel confident they won't make a mistake.

People come to us overwhelmed, anxious, and worried about screwing this up financially. FOSU—fear of screwing up—is the dominant emotion.

And it's justified. Housing is the largest financial decision most people will ever make. It determines whether their kids go to college, whether they can retire, whether generational wealth gets built or destroyed.

So in practice, trust means:
- Showing empathy early (we acknowledge this is hard and the market is challenging)
- Being honest about market realities (no false promises)
- Backing that up with expert guidance and tools that create clarity
- Making people feel less alone in the process

The disconnect is brutal right now. People want the American Dream. But first-time buyers are approaching age 40. Inventory is constrained. Rates have been high. The dream feels unattainable.

No other brand in our category was acknowledging that. They were still pushing aspiration—beautiful homes, happy families, "your dream is waiting."

We made a different choice: meet people where they are. Recognize the challenge. Then show them how professional expertise gives them an edge.

○ **Follow-up:** Is fear of making the *wrong* decision more powerful than the dream of making the *right* one?

- Right now? Yes. Absolutely.
  Here's why: the consequences of a wrong decision in housing compound for decades. You're stuck with a mortgage you can't afford. Trapped in a neighborhood that doesn't work. Watching your home lose value while your friends' homes appreciate.
  The dream is still there—people still want homeownership. But fear is the more immediate emotion.

  · In vacation rentals, earning trust means removing uncertainty before the stay even begin. It's not a standard product like a hotel, so people want to know exactly what they're getting and that someone has their back if something goes wrong. So, earning trust means consistency, clear expectations, verified reviews, and policies that give people peace of mind before they arrive—not after they're already stressed.

    ○ **Follow-up:** Is the fear about the house or about the people you're responsible for having a good time?

  · Earning trust means being honest through change and delivering when it matters. When you're at the mercy of the weather and your equipment, unplanned events are going to happen. So, on the day of travel, in customer care, with our frontline employees—the experience still needs to feel proactive, human and fair. That same approach applies to the larger transformation happening at Southwest, for example… Assigned seating was a big shift, and earning trust meant taking people with us—explaining why, listening, and giving them time to process.

    ○ **Follow-up:** Is there a point where explanation stops mattering and delivery is the only thing customers care about?

What's interesting to me… is that none of you described trust as simply a feeling you create. In many cases, it's something you remove... Confusion. Fear. Uncertainty. And that changes what marketing actually needs to do.

Act II: Emotional Connection as a Competitive Advantage

In high-consideration categories during uncertain times, people default to brands that feel both competent and steady. Emotional connection isn't a nice-to-have—it reduces perceived risk and accelerates decision-making.

Neil, Housing might be the highest-stakes decision any of us discuss today. How do you think about the emotional architecture of home search and purchase?

- Realtor.com was born of the National Association of REALTORS. We've always been the most trusted platform by the industry—"the #1 site real estate professionals trust."
- We're proud of that. But that's a functional claim. It doesn't automatically translate to emotional connection with homebuyers.
- We needed to move from functional to emotional. The question was: what's the emotional architecture that makes sense for our category?
- There's a brutal disconnect between people's goals and market reality. What was once a clear path—save money, buy a starter home, trade up to a dream home—is now blocked by economic realities.
  Average age of first-time buyer approaching 40. Rate of Black homeownership worse now than in 1968 when Fair Housing Act passed. The American Dream is slipping away. No other brand was acknowledging that challenge. They were still selling aspiration.
- **The opportunity:** Our deep expertise in the industry—direct MLS partnerships, 1.5M REALTORS, Economics team, News Corp partnership—gave us tools that actually make finding the right home simpler.
  In a category where the dream feels unattainable, people aren't looking for more aspiration. They're looking for an Expert Edge.
  That positioning—where professional expertise becomes your advantage—is guiding everything we do.

Spoiler alert, this foundational strategy work led to an amazing campaign—one of the top performing bodies of work in the company's history, right? – Talk to us about how you took this positioning and brought it to life. It's one thing to have a great positioning and a whole 'nother mountain to climb to make it resonate creatively.

- We designed a campaign & celebrity partnership that reflected the actual buyer journey and prove we're the most trusted brand to help you through it.
  We created a Realtor.com mini-sitcom called "Nearly Home" featuring a couple in the midst of searching for their next home. We used real homebuying insights—they're stressed, overwhelmed, dealing with chaos—and showed how Realtor.com's tools help them resolve it.
- Any great sitcom needs a star. Ours would be a symbol of empathy, realness, accomplishment, and a sitcom icon herself: Reba McEntire.
  Here's why Reba works:
  - She understands what it takes to put in hard work to achieve dreams
  - She's spent 50 years building trust through consistency—people know her, believe her
  - She's actually owned real estate and made these decisions herself
  - She played a REALTOR on her hit TV show "Reba" for six years—which almost every media outlet mentioned when we launched
  - She can sing AND act—two things you don't always get from celebrity partnerships
  Her presence telegraphed empathy and trustworthiness to the brand instantly.
- THE FORMAT:
  Great sitcoms are defined by their houses. The Tanner house in Full House. The apartment in Friends. The Banks mansion in Fresh Prince.
  These homes become characters—familiar, comforting, aspirational. People recognize them instantly and build emotional attachment.
  When we put Reba in a sitcom about real estate, we weren't just leveraging a format. We were tapping into decades of cultural memory where sitcom houses represent belonging, family, and home.
  That familiarity created immediate trust. Audiences didn't have to learn a new visual language. They already knew how to feel.
  There was also a practical reason: about a third of our media runs on YouTube where people can skip after five seconds. The sitcom framing made it feel less like an ad. Engagement rates proved people wanted to watch.
  These strategic and creative choices let us tell specific stories that prove the value of using Realtor.com in your search.

< PLAY NEARLY HOME>

- When stakes are high, the brain prioritizes certainty over novelty. That's behavioral science
  We weren't trying to make people love Realtor.com. We were trying to make them confident enough to use it for the biggest financial decision of their lives. And it worked: +17% response lift over prior creative. All three Season 1 spots performed in the same improvement range. Seven consecutive months of brand health improvement following launch.
  Emotional loyalty in high-consideration categories isn't about joy. It's about confidence. And confidence that gets proven under pressure becomes loyalty.

Act III: Technology Serves Human Connection, Doesn't Replace It

We're living through a moment where technology is accelerating faster than trust. AI can answer questions faster than ever. Algorithms can personalize at scale. But none of that automatically makes people feel safe making big decisions. Information is abundant. Reassurance is not.

So the question is how all this amazing technology can get deployed at the right moment to help people feel confident when the stakes are high. Do consumers feel supported or left alone with information overload?

Helen, Vrbo sits between hosts and guests… two humans who need to trust each other. How does your platform facilitate that trust? What role does technology play in creating emotional safety when you're booking someone else's home?

- **Marketplace dynamics:** Let's start with any two-sided marketplace business. Unfortunately, perfect quality is the sacrifice of volume. Just look at Ebay, Uber, Etsy. So, the question for us is how do you build trust when you don't own the end product?
- **You can't own trust if you don't acknowledge the real experience.** We're at a stage in time in vacation rentals maturity curve where everyone knows someone who had a less than great experience. The keypad doesn't work, the host is staying on the property when you didn't expect it, the pictures don't reflect reality.
- **Most people aren't looking for an over the top experience.** They just want it to be what they expect. And for our target audience, the person who's coordinating a group vacation—and likely has some neuroses that come with taking responsibility for people's vacations—a trip that goes to plan is one of the most delightful things that can happen.
- **We want to perfect the stay before it happens:** Our aim is to turn insecurity into security. It means we spend a lot of time thinking about the brilliant basics that make a VR stay predictable – exactly as advertised.
- **Tools that do that across the journey:**.
    - Upfront, helping w/ tech/features that help them find the perfect match
    - Because we don't own the end vacation experience, the host is where your trip goes from good to exceptional. So, through well-communicated merchandising algorithms, we better rank the homes of hosts who respond quickly, acceptance more bookings/don't cancel them, get the

best reviews, have the most reviews that mention cleanliness, etc. In short, we unlock more benefits to the host the more they do what Vrbo needs you to do to deliver a great stay.

- And if something goes wrong, we want to show up as a brand that has your back – VrboCare is an industry-leading policy.

It's so true – it's hard to believe you'll have a great vacation if the basics aren't there. As a recovering group trip planner, it resonates deeply. Talk to us about how you create a campaign about the basics without it seeming… well, basic?

- **The campaign:** Basics don't have to be boring! Vrbo has incredible policies like VrboCare, Verified Reviews and Loved by Guest listings that build trust. The campaign communicates that with our trusted product you always know what you're going to get... and it connects emotionally through smart, observational humor about the most surprising part of vacation… the you're traveling with on vacation, not the house.

< PLAY SURPRISE-FREE VACATIONS>

So fun to see another great product marketing campaign that is also so clearly building the brand. You and Neil have both played in this areas, so I want to go back to the product roadmap for a moment. Can we talk more about how you see AI showing up for consumers in the future?

- We’re trying to be super thoughtful about it. We’re using AI to build trust at a time when people might be questioning it.
- So, our product roadmap looks at it through two paths… make us more efficient AND deliver greater traveler benefit. We find that people want AI to help them finesse their findings, not just give them the answer… and that’s probably pretty different than the role it plays in homebuying where you just want the perfect home to materialize.

- Follow the consumer. Swim upstream or meet them where they are.
- Examples from Customer Care group here? (15 Below)

- We're #1 in AI Brand Favorability—most cited and trusted in LLM outputs
  That matters because when someone asks ChatGPT or Perplexity about buying a home, we want the answer sourced from verified, professional-grade data—not scraped content
- Our AI advantage doesn't replace REALTORS. It makes them more credible. Consumers arrive already informed, so the professional conversation starts from a higher level.
- The principle: AI should amplify human expertise, not replace it.
- Data wins when it's interpreted. AI wins when it reduces confusion, not just time saved.
- And critically—we measure whether AI is building trust or eroding it. If performance goes up but trust goes down, we stop. Because we know that performance is built on borrowed trust, and eventually the bill comes due.

ACT IV: Creative Strategy in Volatile Times—What Really Works?

Man, the future is bright. We've talked a good deal about how marketplace products are evolving to meet consumer needs, but that's a little different than the Southwest product offering which requires more time to evolve by nature of being a metal tube that flies through the air. So, I want to dig in on how creative strategy can be the tip of the spear to build trust when the product needs a moment to catch-up.

This is no easy job. In this environment, high-consideration brands can no longer rely on aspiration or generic optimism. Plus, with the number of different channels in play, creative work now needs to work so much harder to breakthrough. At GSD&M, this has us embracing the principles of How Brands Grow (make your brand more distinctive) while also leaning into perceived differentiation (make your brand feel like it offers something unique to the category).

Jen, Southwest has been on a journey balancing those two things – the brand is known for being distinctive. It has always brought warmth and humor to a somewhat self-serious category. But the last year for Southwest has also brought its product offering closer to what other airlines offer. Can you talk about how the brand is maintaining trust in the midst of this change? And after that, let's talk about what it means for the creative strategy.

- **Customer-first approach** and really understanding what the SWA Customer looks like moving forward. We had a reckoning coming out of the pandemic, it really changed expectations of what people want. We needed to expand our offering and that was a driver of ELR and new products.
- **As we expanded offering, it was critical to retain our soul.**
  - First, we've always been a transparent brand – just look at Transfarency. And over the last year we've learned that people need to time to process the change. You can't just say 'hey this is different' and expect them to come along the journey.
  - Assigned seating, when we first announced it in Sep 2024, we got a lot of trepidatious feedback, but ultimately, as more and more consumers have heard about it, we're both feeling the excitement from people AND seeing new bookers grow. It's just proof that we had to give customers time to process – change management so so so important.
  - It's also led to more transparency in communications – we've created lots of education content, and ensured that it matched the guest type –

from infrequent, to credit card holders. That impacts the frequency + dimensionalization of message.

- **We're also investing in the frontline humans** that Customers interact with every day, this is the place that emotional connection is really born for the brand.
  - We're educating and identifying evangelists amongst our employees to help them embrace and champion the change. Our people also show up best when there's a little fight in the belly, so as a part of all of this change, we've actually launched an internal campaign – Watch Us Fly! Making sure we don't lose the fun and swagger that makes a SWA flight feel like a SWA flight.
  - We've also spent a lot of time really looking at our experience (day-of travel and what that looks like with the new boarding process, what happens when someone calls CS). That way our brand feels consistent, even as some of the experience changes.

Makes sense. Southwest has always been more human, more light-hearted than other airlines. And that can be a really positive signpost that some of the most adored parts of the airline aren't changing. How does that translate to communications?

- Recent campaigns around Assigned Seats had a tough job – we needed to build some goodwill back. And we know that when brands are late to deliver what people want, trying to spin it can breed cynicism—but self-aware honesty can transform skepticism into love. We knew that assigned seating wasn't groundbreaking news. Every other airline already had it; our own loyalists joked we might be a little late to the party. We wrestled with how to announce it: as innovation? As giving control? As "you asked, we listened?"
- Ultimately we wanted to transform routine product news into reassurance: Southwest's brand hasn't changed, even if its seating policy has. So, we celebrated the announcement with radical self-awareness, hyping assigned seating like we'd reinvented air travel, to disarm critics and delight fans.
- It was so important to keep the humor + wit to signpost that we're still us, with new products that are attractive to 84% of the consumers who wouldn't fly us because we didn't have assigned seats.

< PLAY ARE YOU SITTING DOWN>

Gets me every time. The watermelon! And how'd that work for y'all?

- It was well-received by current customers and super effective at breaking through with new customers, so we doubled down on it and just a few weeks ago during the Super Bowl, we followed it up with a second chapter in the campaign.

- Customers can now sit in assigned seats, and we wanted to remind people that they're here, not just to book, but to sit in. And commemorating the Open Seating in a light-hearted way during a tentpole moment was just too good of an opportunity. We shone that self-aware light back on the brand.

< PLAY BOARDING ROYALE >

Follow-up: That. Was. Wild. What did radical honesty unlock that polish never could?

Radical honesty bought us patience and permission. When we stopped trying to make the change sound perfect and instead acknowledged the really human feelings that existed for the large majority of consumers who weren't flying us (and even many who were!), we got grace.

Helen, Neil, Kate react. Think:

- Follow-up question for Neil
- "Oh, we see the same" or "Oh, we see the opposite"

Act V: Rapid Fire: Trust, Tech, and What's Next (If Time Allows)

- **Borrowed vs. Owned Trust:** Do partnerships (influencers, third-party validation, expert endorsements) accelerate trust or dilute it?
- **Generational Shifts:** Are younger consumers engaging differently with high-consideration decisions? What assumptions need updating?
- **The Loyalty Paradox:** Consumers say they're loyal, and conventional wisdom says that trust should lead to more of it… but people shop around more than ever. What's real loyalty in 2026? Do you think trust impacts it?

Closing Perspective

Thank you all for sharing your perspectives, I want to recap our conversation… Today the biggest thing I'm hearing is that trust isn't built in the moment of need it's built long before the moment of risk. These brands aren't winning because they have more tech. They're winning because they're deploying it to reduce confusion and respect anxiety. And then humanizing it through communications. In uncertain times, staying consistent goes a long way to build confidence! And might even provoke the question… 'when and where do things get hard for consumers shopping in my category? And where should our brand show up when things get hard?'

WRAP SLIDE:

1. **Reduce uncertainty** (not eliminate it—that's impossible— help people navigate it)
2. **Humanize complexity** (through expertise, clarity, or genuine service)
3. **Behave consistently when the market wobbles** (brand isn't what you say, it's how you act under pressure)